overseas, such as Rabello, Esusa, Ecisa, Affonseca and others that went into bankruptcy and ceased work abroad. In other words, a good number of these firms, corresponding to 17.4% of the civil engineering firms in foreign markets, no longer have activities there and the market has become more concentrated in only five firms, which today take practically all of the overseas contracts.

Therefore, as has been shown, the Brazilian contractors' internationalisation process is not generalised among various-sized Brazilian heavy construction firms. On the contrary, we are dealing with the typical expansion of big capital headed by the firms considered leaders in the domestic public works market.[7]

In search of an explanation

The data treated in the present research has confirmed the hypotheses with which we have been working. Without ignoring such accounts of the phenomenon as the thesis of Brazilian sub-imperialism, we think that the explanation given by Ruy Mauro Marini and his followers is not sufficient to elucidate the internationalisation of Brazilian firms. This is because what explains their overseas activity is the experience and large-scale capitalisation that firms underwent in Brazil before and mostly during the civil-military dictatorship (1964–88), rather than market constriction. Hence these firms were involved in various economic sectors in the domestic market and, because of their size and technical expertise, were able to execute similar works overseas. Assisted by ample state support and favouritism, this expansion occurred above all in such priority regions as South America and especially sub-Saharan Africa where Brazilian foreign policy was able to operate with greatest force and intensity.

Thus, on the basis of the data presented, we reaffirm[8] the following: in Brazil we have monopoly and international capital that not only exports capital but also seems to possess great influence in determining the direction of domestic public policy and foreign policy. Therefore, the international standing of the state and Brazilian capital should no longer be interpreted as within the rules of underdevelopment, of complete dependence or subordination to the contemporary interstate capitalist system. The Brazilian pattern of capital accumulation and the monopolistic size of certain domestic groups point more towards a relative autonomy of the state and Brazilian capital in a situation of complex dependence in which the country stays in a kind of economic subordination in relation to the central poles of the international system. However, the country behaves as an 'imperialist' power over other countries (such as those in South America and, to a lesser degree, those of the African continent), where Brazil presents itself as an exporter of manufactured goods and capital with superior technology and as an